

What else to watch: *Pather Panchali* (1955, pp.132–33) ■ *Whistle Down the Wind* (1961) ■ *Cria Cuervos* (1976) ■ *Fanny and Alexander* (1982)



Obsessed by visions of the monster, although not afraid of him, Ana goes home. Here, in echoing, shadowy rooms behind honeycomb-shaped windows, her bookish beekeeper father and her far younger mother seem impossibly far apart, literally and emotionally, as her mother

Teresa (Teresa Gimpera) writes sad letters to an unknown young man.

Ana's sister Isabela fuels Ana's visions, telling her to close her eyes and call the monster, like a spirit. When Ana closes her eyes and calls, "It's me, Ana," she finds, hidden in the outhouse, a haunted-looking young man, presumably a Republican on the run, who she believes is the monster. They develop a

Ana and her sister Isabel talk with their father (Fernando Fernán Gómez). He keeps bees, and writes of his revulsion for their mindless lives, one of many allusions to Francoist Spain.

tender relationship, but the Francoist troops are never far away. Ana has more visions of the monster, although the doctor reassures her mother that the delusions will pass.

Political allegory

The movie ends with an image of Ana at the window, her eyes closed again. When the movie was made in 1973, Franco's regime was already faltering; its end would have felt very near to a Spanish audience. Telling a story from the past, *The Spirit of the Beehive* also gave Spain a glimpse of its future. ■

“Little but the walls remain of the house you once knew, I often wonder what became of everything we had there.”

Teresa / The Spirit of the Beehive



Victor Erice Director

Victor Erice is regarded by many as Spain's finest movie director. Yet he has made few movies. Indeed, his high reputation rests on just two poetic works, *The Spirit of the Beehive* and *The South*, both of which are period pieces centering on rural childhoods.

Erice was born in Karrantza in the Basque country (Spain) in 1940, around the same time *The Spirit of the Beehive* is set. He studied economics, law and politics at the University of Madrid before going to film school in the early 1960s. He worked for almost a decade as a film critic before making a series of short movies.

The Spirit of the Beehive was Erice's first feature-length movie, but he did not make his second, *The South* (*El Sur*), until almost 10 years later. Ten years after that, he made a beautiful documentary, *The Quince Tree Sun*, about the painter Antonio López García. While Erice has contributed to other work, these have been his only feature-length movies.

Key movies

1973 *The Spirit of the Beehive*
1983 *The South*
1992 *The Quince Tree Sun*